

| By Jason Burke in London |

The statements were all variations on the same theme. Everywhere in the world, leaders last week stepped forward on behalf of hundreds of millions of people to offer condolences and support. It was a global outpouring of sympathy in an era of globalised terrorism. Whoever is responsible for the Mumbai attacks, their roots will lie in both globalised jihadi ideologies and local problems: Kashmir, Gujarat, Pakistan. They will have consequences in communities from Seattle to Soho and those consequences will be heavily influenced by how the international community views the attacks, who they blame and what their view is of India.

In the West, India is viewed primarily as an engine of economic growth and a democracy and is, therefore, seen as a natural ally. New Delhi may want to cash this in to build an international coalition to fight terror and, particularly, to eradicate for the foreseeable future the possibility that Pakistan will be the source of violence on Indian soil. However, this may be much more difficult than it may currently seem—especially when it comes to actual concrete commitments.

CONDOLEEZZA
RICE (LEFT)
WITH PRANAB
MUKHERJEE



Fingerpointing WON'T DO

India is unlikely to get an international coalition going or get concrete commitments from major powers to curb Pakistan

For, though the attacks in Mumbai have stunned India, they have merely shocked the rest of the world. Many countries have been touched by the scourge of terrorism in recent years and the response of the international community is likely to be “join the club” not “let’s start a new one”. Any attempt to build a new international coalition against terrorism is likely to be met with a degree of bemusement. After all, seven years after 9/11 there are already well-established formal and informal networks of cooperation. There is another factor too. One senior European diplomat, speaking to *INDIA TODAY*, talked of how powers such as France, Germany and the UK were likely to “wait until the dust has settled” before making any moves adding, “The aim is to calm everyone down, not to take sides.”

Equally, no one, at this critical juncture in Afghanistan, wants to further destabilise Pakistan.

This is in part why the investigation into the attacks is being so closely followed across the world. So far the only consensus among foreign intelligence services about the attack is that they are a) very difficult to decipher and, b) the current account that has leaked from Indian sources is likely to just be a part of the truth. Most analysts are sure that the Pakistani government is not to blame. As most now discount the idea that the ISI would act alone, this means that if the attack did originate in Pakistan, the army would have likely known about it. Another alternative is that some breakaway group within a militant organisation such as Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) is responsible.

Then there is the Al Qaeda or the ‘homegrown’ theory. One element making the Mumbai attacks so difficult to interpret is that tactically they involved elements that had all been seen before but brought together in a completely new way. In